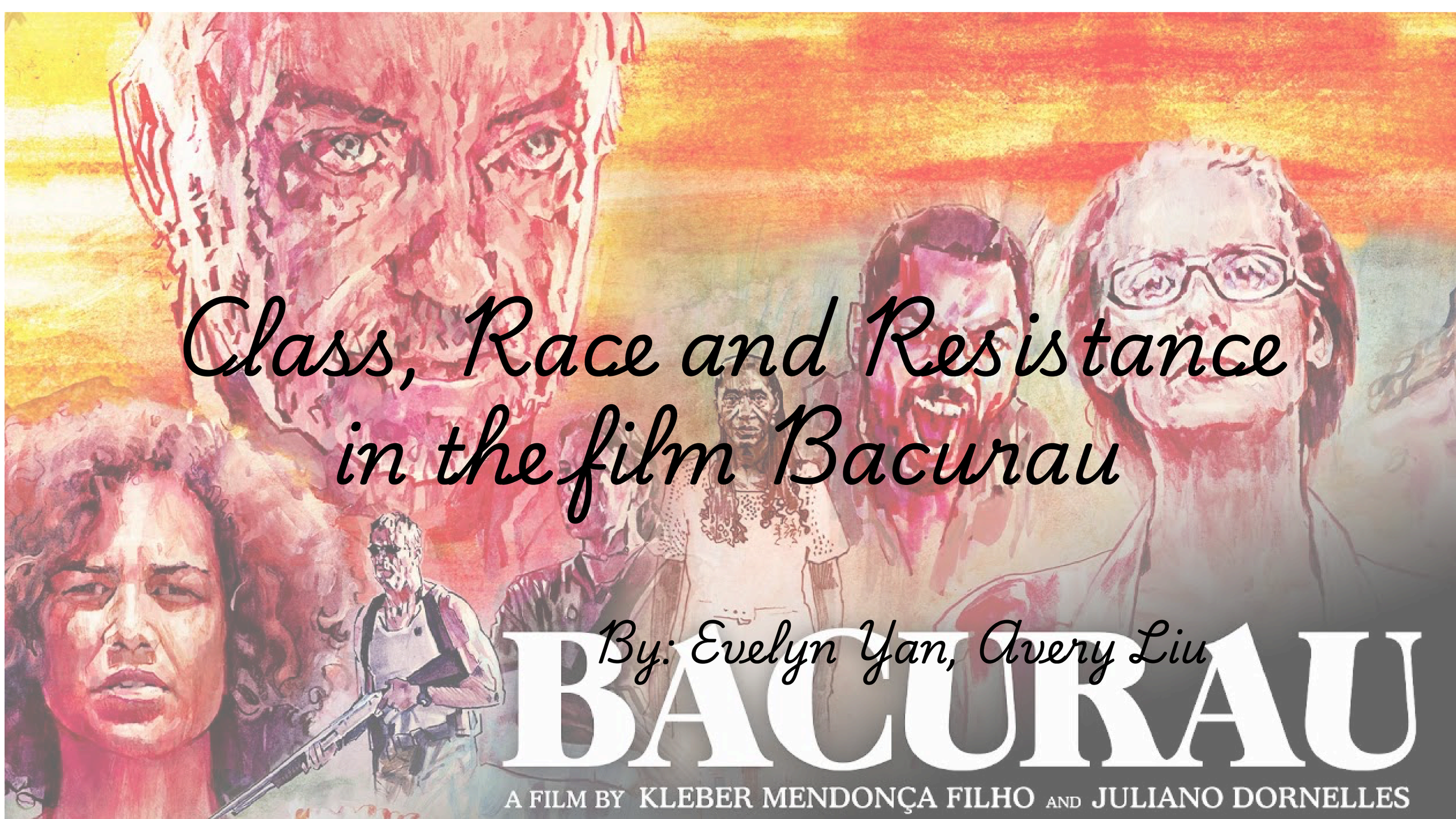


Class, Race and Resistance in the film Bacurau

By: Evelyn Yan, Avery Liu

Resistance, Race, and Class in the film ***Bacurau***

- This presentation will explore how Bacurau uses a fusion of science fiction, Western, and political allegory to expose racial class violence and neocolonial dynamics in Brazil.

Introduction: Why Bacurau

- Directed by Kleber Mendonça Filho and Juliano Dornelles, Bacurau (2019) has garnered international acclaim and won the Jury Prize at the Cannes Film Festival. It is an ideal work for analyzing issues such as race, class, colonialism, and power in Brazilian cinema.

- While Bacurau incorporates elements of science fiction and Westerns, it realistically reflects Brazil's structural historical problems—particularly the long-term political neglect, resource exploitation, and cultural marginalization of impoverished regions in the northeast. Through violence and absurd foreigner invasion, the film juxtaposes global power inequality, transnational racial violence, and the resilience of local communities, allowing viewers to see the connection between class disparities, racial stratification, and neo-colonialism in real-world Brazil.

Main Plot Summary:

Bacurau follows a small, impoverished village in Brazil's Northeast that mysteriously disappears from digital maps shortly after the death of a beloved elder. As strange events unfold—such as water shortages, attacks, and the appearance of foreign armed tourists—the villagers realize they are the targets of a deadly human-hunting game organized by wealthy white outsiders with the support of corrupt local politicians. Instead of accepting their fate, the community unites, draws on its history of resistance, and fights back collectively to reclaim their land, dignity, and survival.

Research Questions & Main Argument

Main Arguments:

- Bacurau exposes racialized class violence in Brazil and the global neo-colonial system.

Research Questions:

- How does the film depict racialized rural poverty?
- How does the film portray contemporary colonial violence?
- How do race and class shape resistance?
- How does the film challenge power narratives

How we study Race and Power in the film

- How different factors such as skin color, wealth, and gender simultaneously affect people's lives.
- Who holds power, and who does not—especially who is protected, and who is ignored or harmed.
- How foreigners, those from powerful nations, come here to control or exploit vulnerable groups.
- How people with darker skin or from impoverished areas are treated differently and often face greater danger.
- Why do the state and global capitalist forces treat rural, poor, and predominantly non-white communities like Bacurau as expendable or disposable populations?

Historical & Social Context



Social Context: 2016–2019 (Bolsonaro Era):

- Anti-poverty rhetoric, increased violence
- Rural land expropriation and inequality

Film Background:

- Lack of the water.
- The digital erasure of Bacurau village – The government removed Bacurau village from digital maps and GPS systems, making it “disappear.” Outsiders cannot find it, and the village becomes invisible to the nation.
- Neo-colonial land acquisition by white foreigners

Clip 1: The Funeral Scene



Scene Description:

- Community gathers for a funeral.
- Afro-Brazilians and indigenous villagers are central figures.
- showcases emotional solidarity and a shared identity.

Race:

- The non-white group is placed at the center
- Highlights diversity often erased in Brazilian media.
- Asserts dignity of racialized rural communities.

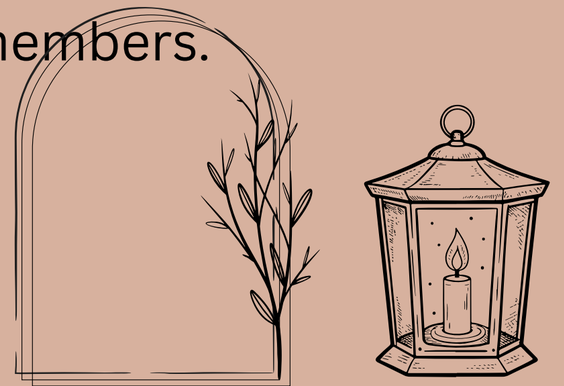


Class:

- The poverty of the working class in rural areas is clearly visible
- The simple ceremony reflects the scarcity of resources
- Despite poverty, strong social bonds exist among community members.

Resistance:

- Unity in grief—this is the foundation of collective resistance
- The community has united
- Emotional solidarity transforms into political power.



Clip 2: The Museum Scene

Scene Description:

- A hidden museum houses weapons, photographs, and artifacts
- The villagers reopen their long-forgotten history.
- Taking up weapons symbolize reconnecting with their ancestors.



Race:

- The history of resistance by Black and Indigenous peoples is refocused
- Counters erasure in official narratives
- The villagers reclaim their racialized historical subjectivity



Class:

- An impoverished rural community with rich political memories
- Challenging the passive stereotype of rural life
- Demonstrating the historical empowerment of the working class

Resistance:

- Major turning point: from victims to fighters
- Resistance becomes intergenerational transmission
- Collective memory becomes a weapon.



Clip 3: The Battle Scene



Scene Description:

- The entire community participates in coordinated defense
- Strategic ambushes are conducted using local knowledge
- Outsiders underestimate them

Race:

- White hunters view the villagers as “savages”
- The scene overturns the colonial-era racial hierarchy
- Brazilians defeat the colonizers through their wisdom



Class:

- Poor rural villagers confront wealthy, armed foreigners
- Class inequality is exposed and reversed
- The collective strength of the working class overcomes the violence of the elite.

Resistance:

- No lone wolf – the community unites.
- Organized, strategic, collective resistance
- Reclaims land, autonomy, and dignity





Conclusion

- ***Bacurau*** integrates race, class, and resistance into a core idea: marginalized communities can also reclaim their power. The film places Afro-Brazilians and Indigenous peoples back at the center of the narrative, viewing ethnic identity as a source of culture and strength; poverty is presented as a politically induced consequence, but communities transform scarcity into unity through mutual aid and sharing; resistance is not individual heroism, but the result of collective memory and cooperation. These three elements combined demonstrate that even groups erased from the state can reshape their future through unity.

Discussion Question

- Does "Bacurau" present realistic collective resistance or a political fantasy?

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